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ANALYZING GENDER

A Handbook of Social Science Research

"Introduction"

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Introduction

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ONE way of dating the feminist revolution in the social sciences is to begin from the publication of Marcia Millman and Rosabeth Kanter's *Another Voice* in 1975. This was hardly the first feminist contribution to the social sciences of recent years, nor was it the first collection of feminist essays provoked by the reemergence of an organized women's movement in the 1960s. Nonetheless, it marked the beginning of an era of feminist social science.

Before *Another Voice* the many daring and original articles that connected feminist concerns to the practices and issues of social science appeared primarily in movement publications. These essays were only gradually collected into books aimed at a mass market (e.g., Morgan, 1970; Gornick and Moran, 1971). Relatively little of this early intellectual ferment appeared in established academic sources or was directed to specifically academic audiences. By the early 1970s, researchers influenced by the burgeoning women's movement began to frame their questions about the status of women in social scientific terms. The first notable collection of such work, *Changing Women in a Changing Society* (1973), edited by Joan Huber, originally appeared as a special issue of the *American Journal of Sociology*. The first edition of Jo Freeman's *Women: A Feminist Perspective* (1975) also brought together original synthesizing essays that challenged traditional theories and conclusions about women. *Another Voice*, however, more than these or other early collections, began to move in the direction of developing feminist theory. The volume provided integrated and comprehensive critiques of the social sciences from a feminist perspective, pushing the field beyond the simple "add-women-and-stir" formula for incorporating women into existing paradigms of research.

Another Voice made clear that there were feminist questions that had not yet been imagined and that the answers would demand a fundamental transformation of the social sciences. Provocative problems were posed in that volume including many that remain unresolved: What class position do

women hold? Why is deviance for women equated with sexuality? What kind of work is housework and whom does it benefit? What does male-centered education do to women? By asking searching questions of all the major institutional areas studied by the social sciences, *Another Voice* was a revolutionary book. As a pioneering work, it was also seriously limited by existing gaps in theory and research. Nonetheless, the essays stimulated an entire generation of feminist social scientists to realize that the questions existed and the answers were significant.

In the years since *Another Voice* the work of feminist social scientists directed to these issues has become impressive in its scope, quality, and significance. Major journals in all the social sciences regularly publish studies focusing on women, if not typically ones that challenge presuppositions of the field. Journals with a specific focus on gender issues have been establishing this concern as a significant speciality. The literature on gender continues to grow exponentially until it is now a double-edged sword: The sweep and richness of this work are exciting to scholars already in the area, but may be daunting to newcomers, be they graduate students or faculty.

The present volume is an attempt to provide an overview of feminist perspectives in the social sciences today. Like any survey of a rapidly changing field, it cannot claim to be definitive. It is an effort, however, to move out and away from questions toward answers. Collections that pose feminist challenges to the standard paradigms of the social sciences have become common (e.g. Sherman and Beck, 1979; Spender, 1981; Roberts, 1981; Bowles and Duelli-Klein, 1983). It is our premise that feminist research has now multiplied and matured sufficiently to allow a self-reflective examination of what has been accomplished and where further work is needed. While the chapters of this volume vary in scope and in style, they share a common concern with articulating what we know and what we need to know about the significance of gender in social organization. Because this book is intended as a compendium in the social sciences of feminist research on gender, it is important to clarify what is meant by each of these terms.

THE DOMAIN OF SOCIAL SCIENCE

The interdisciplinary focus of women's studies is central to its self-definition. The journals of this field, such as *Signs* or *Feminist Studies*, make deliberate and largely successful efforts to cross the boundaries of traditional disciplines and to develop new knowledge that fits women better than it fits the traditional pigeonholes of academic discourse. In this context, it would be impossible to present an overview of feminist research that confined itself to the territory of any one conventional discipline. Scholars trained to respect the boundaries of academic departments tend to ask, "Is it economics?" or "Is it psychology?" before considering whether a research question is important

and to whom. This sort of disciplinary fencing is not really feasible for the feminist research surveyed here. Although authors were chosen who hold positions in a variety of social science departments and whose disciplinary training is also diverse, the areas they cover spread across traditional lines. They incorporate perspectives more characteristic of the fundamentally interdisciplinary nature of women's studies than of their own fields.

At the same time, the authors are not representative of all of women's studies either, as they share a focus and perspective that distinguishes them as social scientists. The perspective can loosely be called "structural": Attention is directed outward from the individual to the social structures that shape experience and meaning, that give people a location in the social world, and that define and allocate economic and social rewards. This type of analysis is quite different from that appropriate for self-referential symbol systems such as literary texts or from other types of scientific endeavor. Even within the social sciences a structural perspective is not always applied; some scholars take the individual as the basic unit, with social organization added on. From a structural perspective, however, individuality itself is a social product.

Because most research within the social sciences has suffered from systematic biases regarding women, feminists see a need for correction on several levels. The most elementary is the recognition of absence—that women have been excluded from consideration, and that many of the most meaningful issues have not been addressed. The process of filling these voids has moved rapidly enough in most disciplines that it is now evident that these omissions were there for a reason. Recognition of the systematic nature of these gaps demands a rethinking of basic conceptual frameworks, including a reexamination of how women and men are differentiated. The emergent feminist perspective represented in this book defines this difference in social structural, rather than individual, terms.

Feminist critics have also described a number of biases within the social sciences that go beyond the simple exclusion of women from entire areas of study and the failure to explore the social origins of differences between men and women. The choice of different concepts, interpretations, and even language for describing women's experience has often been made in the context of a tendency to devalue the female as an expression of an intrinsically lesser nature. Because social scientific thought has been formulated by men, placing men at the center, and with men as the intended audience, women have been transformed into objects without consciousness, existing only in relation to men. As Dorothy Smith explained it, the social sciences constitute a community of discourse with a momentum of its own, a landscape in which even the most accomplished women scholars are in part strangers because it fails to incorporate their experience of reality, even as an African child brought up on British books finds a division between the mental and physical worlds of experience (1979: 138-139).

Moreover, there has been an inclination to press an abstract dichotomy

mization by sex on the natural diversity of humanity, ignoring variation within each group and reifying group differences as an attribute of persons. Male and female have been taken as opposite ends of a continuum, as discrete and non-overlapping categories, and as biologically defined traits rather than as socially constructed labels that carry a situationally variable degree of significance (Lopata and Thorne, 1978). For example, sociologists understood "being blind" as a social construct before being able to recognize "being male" as similarly socially defined (see Scott, 1969), despite the ubiquity of rituals for establishing and asserting "manhood."

Because of these biases, the structural perspective characteristic of the social sciences has not yet been consistently and coherently applied to men and women as such. The feminist project demands reconceptualization of what "male" and "female" mean in terms of the social systems that organize perception, identity, action, and the allocation of costs and benefits for all people. "Maleness" and "femaleness" are then perceived consequences of the operation of these social systems on the variability provided by nature rather than as the property of individuals abstracted from their culture. This is a perspective that is as distinctively social as it is feminist.

DOING FEMINIST RESEARCH

There is today, also, an expanding literature on feminist methodology in the social sciences that attempts systematically to consider how to do research that is more consistent with this theoretical approach (see the annotated bibliography in Bowles and Duelli-Klein, 1983). There are several premises central to the practice of feminist research that inform many of the chapters of this book.

First, there is a fundamental rejection of the ideal of value-free research in favor of a conscious partiality. The increased visibility of the once unconscious bias toward a male-defined, male-centered world in the supposedly value-free research of the past has exposed this ideal as a political myth. There is also a theoretical objection to the idea that any significant work can be done without a perspective or theory behind it; any choice of perspective is by definition political because it defines both a community of knowers and objects to be known. The "generalizing impersonal mode" obscures but does not eliminate the reality of a perspective rooted in the experience of a specific, limited community and concrete, everyday activity (Smith, 1979).

This critique is a self-reflective one. It does not suffice to recognize the biases hidden in the generalizing impersonal language of male-defined social science without taking the next step—to uncover and reject the generalizing impersonal when used by white, middle-class feminists to speak of all women (Joseph and Lewis, 1981; Bell-Scott, 1982). Thus feminist methodology

interprets conscious partiality as a mandate for deliberately inclusive research designs and for awareness of the significance of gender, race, and class in constituting the social scientific community of discourse. The various chapters of this book strive to reflect this conscious attention to the diversity of women's voices.

Second, feminist methodology rejects the positivist division between theory and practice, between the researcher and the "object" of research (Mies, 1983; Stacey and Thorne, 1985). The image of science as establishing mastery over subjects, as demanding the absence of feeling, and as enforcing separateness of the knower from the known, all under the guise of "objectivity," has been carefully critiqued even in reference to the physical sciences (e.g., Keller, 1982). Elements that are present in scientific knowing but devalued because they are associated with femaleness—intuition, empathy, and passion—are ignored in the positivist account and eventually distort the actual process of doing science. Yet it is this masculinized image of science, rather than the more complex reality, that the social sciences embraced in their drive to attain academic credibility (Ross, 1979). Feminist social scientists, reclaiming the value of the female, legitimate these very elements that have been denied and repressed in science itself (e.g., Elstain, 1979; Westcott, 1979).

Commitment to these more inclusive forms of knowing discredits the image of the uninvolved spectator as the ideal social scientist. The feminist view encourages research based on engagement in struggle as a means of becoming conscious of social relationships and structures that might otherwise remain obscure (e.g., Reinharz, 1979). The original essays collected here express different sorts of political orientations but share a willingness to make these commitments visible and to use them reflexively as a conceptual tool. This also makes the chapters less static than most reviews of literature tend to be. The authors are empathetic and passionate in their scholarship and thus attuned to the currents of change in society at large as well as in the research literature.

Third, the emerging feminist methodology that is developing is profoundly anti-functional, whether this comes in a conventional or Marxist guise (e.g., Stanley and Wise, 1983). There is a desire to accommodate a holistic view of social structural arrangements as defining situations and limiting the range of possible actions with a recognition of individuals as agents of change. Social structures are viewed as having contradictory impulses rather than as promoting a smooth and satisfactory accommodation between individual needs and social demands. Attention is directed to the conflicts within experience, to the reality of guilt and ambivalence rather than either simple accommodation or resistance to structures that oppress people (Stacey and Thorne, 1985; Stanley and Wise, 1983).

Consequently, the structural perspective in feminist research and in this volume is less deterministic than commonly found in the social sciences. By

insisting on beginning from and remaining true to personal experience, feminist researchers preserve the distinction between knowing what is expected and doing it (e.g. Gerson, 1985). Resistance, ambivalence, conflict, and struggle are key concepts for feminist theory and methodology because of the centrality of the distinction between what is and what ought to be. The view of women as agents of change rather than as merely passive victims of circumstances animates research into how women themselves interpret and respond to structures of opportunity and constraint, but also forces recognition of the limited alternatives for action facing women who wish to resist oppression (Westcott, 1979; Smith, 1979).

The awareness of change and inconsistency within individuals as well as between them has rendered traditional theories of socialization based on assumptions of internalization and compliance obviously inadequate (Stacey and Thorne, 1985; Stanley and Wise, 1983; Weitzman, 1984). Recognition of how people do not become what they are expected to be has produced growing criticism of functionalist ideas embedded in the concepts of "sex role" and "socialization" (Lopata and Thorne, 1978). This critique has been sufficiently expanded to present a profoundly different perspective on female and male as categories of persons, one that centers on the concept of gender.

ANALYZING GENDER

The study of men and women as such has moved through three distinct stages in just the past twenty years, from an emphasis on sex differences through preoccupation with sex roles to the centrality of gender. The sex differences perspective is, of course, the most traditional. It holds that maleness and femaleness are biologically given properties of individuals with clear implications for social behavior of one sort or another. Within this perspective, the egalitarian view is that such sex differences are small relative to intrasex variation, that they are rarely relevant for important behaviors, and that the differences are as likely to be instances of female superiority as male. Historically, a nonegalitarian view of sex differences has been more prevalent; these differences are used to explain male dominance by assuming that they are large, socially significant, and consistently favor men. In both cases, the source of sex differences is either sought among specific biological features or assumed to be known, and is not considered to need social scientific explanation. Within this perspective, the egalitarians have always found themselves on the defensive, trying to demonstrate that the intrinsic differences between men and women are not large or meaningful enough to account for the degree and ubiquity of male domination observed in society.

Politically and conceptually, the move to a sex role socialization model was a great improvement. From this perspective, the biological determinants of maleness and femaleness could be combined with social determination via

upbringing in any proportion of nature and nurture that seemed appropriate. Sex differences were no longer intrinsically important issues, since both large and small differences could be explained by socialization. Egalitarians could not be distinguished from sexists on the matter of magnitude, but rather in the amount of attention they gave to specific socialization practices, especially those of early childhood. If the socialization of very young children was demonstrably different for boys than for girls, then such differences of nurture would be sufficient to account for sex differences in personality or behavior in adulthood.

Given the assumption that socialization practices are more susceptible to change than are biological features, the sex roles debate often confounded questions about the desirability or feasibility of altering relationships between men and women with questions about whether a particular difference could be attributed to nature or to nurture. In fact, as shown in the case of transsexuals, some biological features are more readily altered than social ones. It is also easy to imagine social arrangements that accommodate or compensate for biological differences (e.g., eyeglasses for astigmatism) as well as those that reflect and reinforce biological differences that have been endowed with social significance (e.g., shunning short men or tall women).

A second problem in the literature on sex roles involves the presumption of continuity throughout the life course. Advocates of nurture accepted the premise that early learning was one of the most influential determinants of later behavior and assumed consistency between the behaviors and expectations typical of children (e.g., playing with dolls or trucks) and those of adults (e.g., male or female sex-typed careers). This perspective not only trivializes the consequences of adult learning and change throughout life, but also rests on the idea of an abstract female role that exists apart from any specific interpersonal relationship and without concrete behavioral content. The focus is on personality traits that are presumed to be constant across situations and over the life cycle and that can supposedly be used to predict a wide range of behaviors. As Lopata and Thorne (1978) argue, this is neither the way that sociologists have usually theorized roles nor is it a plausible model of female behavior. The absurdity of speaking of "race roles" or "the black role" brings home the contrast between the structural and situational perspective used for race and class, on the one hand, and the individualized, essentialist view inherent in the sex roles approach on the other.

Just as the awareness of cross-cultural differences in what constituted maleness and femaleness was an important step in moving from a biologically determined view of sex differences to a socialization determined view of sex roles, the increasing evidence of inconsistency of any one individual's behavior across time and in different situations now casts doubt on both of these determinist views. So-called sex roles as personality traits or characteristics of individuals (as in the Bem Sex Role Inventory) are notoriously poor predictors of behaviors. While the naive view or "natural attitude"

supposes people to have a stable and consistent personality developed in infancy, the absence of predictability of behavior from one context to another has long made this essentialist assumption scientifically dubious. Moreover, the only trait that links behaviors as diverse as sewing, nursing, and scrubbing floors is the sex-typing done by the perceiver. The fact that each characteristic could in theory be separately socialized into little girls does not begin to explain why they are packaged together conceptually. The label "female" is itself an abstract categorization that links an incredible diversity of unrelated and frequently inconsistent behavioral expectations and outcomes. To describe anything that receives the label "female" as part of a supposed sex role is to grant it a coherence, consistency, and constancy that the evidence does not justify (see Gerson, 1985).

As a result, recent years have seen the emergence of an entirely new perspective on maleness and femaleness. The key concept in this view is gender, seen as a principle organizing social arrangements, behavior, and even cognition. One of the central elements in gender systems is the taboo against the sameness of male and female, "a taboo which exacerbates the biological differences between the sexes and thereby *creates* gender" (Rubin, 1975: 178). Because the gender system insists on and rewards difference, men and women are created who have an interest in presenting themselves and being perceived as "real" men and "real" women—that is, without elements socially defined as belonging in the other category. As Gayle Rubin put it, "from the standpoint of nature, men and women are closer to each other than either is to anything else—for instance, mountains, kangaroos, or coconut palms . . . the idea that men and women are two mutually exclusive categories must arise out of something other than a non-existent 'natural' opposition. Far from being an expression of natural differences, exclusive gender identity is the suppression of natural similarities" (1975: 179-180) for social purposes and by social means.

The division of labor by sex, whatever it might be in any given society, is then understood to be also an outgrowth of that fundamental taboo rather than the cause of the differences between men and women. Doing gender-specific work is part of what defines "real" men and women as such; so too are gender-specific sexual relations. Gender is not a trait but a system for dividing people into distinct, nonoverlapping categories despite their natural variability on any particular characteristic and regardless of the inconsistency between features that are all supposed to be definitive.

Because the gender system is not a reflection of natural differences, creating gender is a struggle. We all bear "the traces of conscription" into a system that represses parts of our potential and no one ever fully conforms to it. On the other hand, even those individuals who deliberately refuse to take their allotted place in the system cannot escape knowing what it is (Rubin, 1975). Unlike the socialization account of sex roles, the psychic processes central to the gender model include ambivalence, conflict, and rebellion.

can be no such thing as the well-socialized individual who smoothly accommodates all of society's demands because the demands themselves are inconsistent and even contradictory.

Moreover, like other power relations, gender is constantly being renegotiated and reconstituted (Margolis, 1985) and it is particularly visible at boundaries and points of change (Gerson and Peiss, 1985). Because gender is relational rather than essential, structural rather than individual, analyzing gender requires consideration of changes in systems over time. The alteration in social structures themselves as well as variation in individual relations within these gender systems demand attention to both macro and micro levels of structure and of change.

The editors and authors of this volume adopt the gender perspective and analyze its implications for the social sciences. The basic assumption is that gender is a property of systems rather than people, but that it is also important to trace the experiences of people within a gendered social structure. The first part, "Gender and Ideology," examines the meaning of gender and the ways in which gender ideology has been used as an organizing principle for social systems, for knowledge, and for perception itself. The next two sections explore the dynamics of gender understood as a property of social systems: Part II, "Social Control of Female Sexuality," deals with the social construction and organization of sexuality and reproduction; and Part III develops perspectives on "Gender Stratification" in economic relations. The chapters in Part IV, "Gendered Worlds," investigate the consequences of gender for women's lives in selected areas of civil society. The final section, "Gender and the State," considers the significance of gender in relationship to political systems and processes.

PART I: GENDER AND IDEOLOGY

The book opens with anthropologist Christine Ward Gailey's analysis of how and why gender has been constructed in the transition from kinship to state societies. Beginning with an overview of kinship societies, Gailey notes that gender must clearly be distinguished from biological sex in that it is possible to acknowledge at least four "genders": children, for whom reproduction is not relevant; adult males and females of reproductive age; and elders, who occupy a status defined by age rather than reproductive capacity. Because our society emphasizes gender differentiation from cradle to grave, we overlook the significance of cultures that use only one term for children or elders of both sexes. Gailey also distinguishes patriarchy—male dominance through specific kin roles—from other forms of male supremacist society. She draws an interesting parallel between Western industrial societies and Inca culture, where abstract maleness was equated with power, so that men

nations were defined as female. The only universals about gender, Gailey finds, are that it is defined in part independently of biological sex—as when *berdaches* or other transsexuals cross gender lines in a culturally acceptable manner—and that it provides a basis for division of labor in all societies.

Gailey then critically examines existing theories of gender hierarchy and the origins of male supremacy—not only the biological determinism of the myth of “man the hunter” and its most recent apotheosis in sociobiology, but also several of the culturally universalistic schemas proposed by feminist scholars. Gailey finds flaws in arguments based on such dichotomies as public/private or culture/nature, and on structuralist principles of exchange. Eschewing global explanations of women’s subordination, Gailey locates the origins of gender inequality in the history of other forms of stratification, primarily the emergence of the organized state, both precapitalist and capitalist. She argues that especially in class societies women come to be defined solely in terms of membership in this abstract gender category rather than through particular kin-defined identities. As the gender hierarchy is intertwined with these other bases of stratification, Gailey proposes that the agenda for change must challenge all sources of inequality: race, ethnicity, and class, as well as gender.

The significance of beliefs in the inevitability and importance of difference in constructing gender is a starting point for social psychologist Janet Sayers in her analysis of science and feminism. She shows how existing ideas of women as embodiments of domesticity and morality were adapted by the scientific “experts” who replaced religious authorities in the early nineteenth century. Where evangelical beliefs placed women closer to God, the ideology guiding science defined women as closer to nature. As religious orthodoxy lost its power to justify social relations, science emerged as the idiom of debate for social and political questions.

Sayers demonstrates how both feminists and antifeminists sought to bend these ideas to their own purposes. The nineteenth-century scientific investigation of menstruation, brain size, and instincts has parallels in twentieth-century studies of endocrinology and brain lateralization, both in the political agenda guiding such research and in the contrasting interpretations applied to findings. While it is easy to recognize the distortions introduced into nineteenth-century science by the overriding commitment to find some sort of natural difference to account for inequality, it is much more difficult to expose the ideology underlying contemporary science. Unlike earlier efforts, current scientific practice has not yet had its premises disproved by women’s actual success in overcoming the inequities that such science is being used to justify. Convictions about gender not born of data continue to influence priorities, methodologies, interpretations, and the likelihood of publication in the sciences.

Yet Sayers cautions us not to abandon science because it has failed to meet the test of objectivity; rather, feminists can and must enter these fields in order

research toward the goal of transforming power relationships in the wider society. Thus she is as critical of feminist equations of femaleness with nature, the innocent victim of science, as she is of the antifeminist variants of this theme. Sayers also questions whether some feminist reactions to male-defined science might not also rely on the dominant gender ideology that assigns women the moral obligation of tempering male brutality.

The scientific search for sex differences has perhaps nowhere been more feverishly pursued than in psychology, some branches of which have been built precisely on the assumption of such basic differences. Psychologists Kay Deaux and Mary F. Kite begin by examining research on sex similarities and differences in cognitive functioning and personality dispositions, showing once again how gender preconceptions are so deeply entrenched that every aspect of the enterprise is questionable: the assumptions, the instruments, the selection of samples, the disregard of findings of no difference, and the persistence of a gender belief system in the face of disconfirming evidence. The motivation for this intense search for sex differences in traits and attitudes seems to lie in the researchers’ gender beliefs, which posit the necessity of basic sex differences to account for gender inequality.

Deaux and Kite then contrast this approach to that implied by the gender perspective, in which the gender belief system *itself* becomes the object of study. The perceiver, whether psychologist or subject, holds certain beliefs, evaluations, judgments, and attitudes toward women and men. Inherent differences between women and men are thought to be expressed in characteristic behaviors, types of dress and appearance, occupations, and roles. Such essentialist views have directed disproportionate research attention to individual personality measures as defining maleness and femaleness, as basic traits with global consequences, ignoring statistical variability.

Deaux and Kite’s gender analysis sees all these perceptions—of traits, of behaviors, of one’s self and others—as organized by the underlying ideology of the observer. The authors seek to uncover the interrelation of these diverse views and their connections to actual behaviors of women and men in specific situations. This perceiver-focused analysis of gender beliefs highlights the significance of context, especially in those situations where beliefs and behaviors diverge. This perspective leads to a dynamic analysis that not only describes the stereotypes that people hold but also the effects of such stereotypes and the ways in which they change.

PART II: SOCIAL CONTROL OF FEMALE SEXUALITY

If the search for sex differences in brains and psyches has been largely chimerical, one distinction appears ineluctable: sexuality itself. The study of sexuality is a pivotal element in linking gender-based preconceptions to the

and divides acceptable from unacceptable behaviors? What is the nature of erotic power? How is gender inequality expressed in sexual relationships?—are central to the chapter by sociologists Beth E. Schneider and Meredith Gould. These authors have been pioneers in the emerging sociology of sexuality and its challenge to masculinist definitions of what women ought to feel and how they should achieve “true” sexual pleasure (e.g., vaginal orgasm in a heterosexual relationship) and to the traditional social science methods for gathering and interpreting “data.” The starting point for this new area of study is the realization that “social actors possess genitals rather than the other way around”—that is, that sexuality is socially structured, not biologically driven, and that gender is perhaps the most crucial principle around which sexuality is organized. Schneider and Gould argue that the most accurate way to study female sexuality is to pay attention to what women actually say about their experiences. While this has been ignored in the past, women today are reclaiming the power to name what is happening to them in sexual as well as nonsexual relationships.

Schneider and Gould trace the ways in which contemporary women are changing their sexual scripts, noting dilemmas posed by the equation of heterosexuality with violence and domination in much of the feminist literature and by the counterattack on sexuality from the political right. They thus set the stage for a theory of female sexuality that transcends the crippling constraints of heterosexist, reproduction-oriented views of women.

Female reproduction, so central to feminist analysis and antifeminist organizing, is the focus of sociologist Barbara Katz Rothman’s analysis. She notes that although individual women may have conflicting or ambiguous feelings about motherhood, the “feminist position” on the issue has been relatively unproblematic: The key to equality is control over reproductive choice. But today’s questions are not quite as clear-cut, and choice alone will not resolve key ethical dilemmas confronting women who have the power to choose. Control over such choices may also gradually be slipping into the hands of reproductive technicians. Rothman reviews the position of minimalist and maximalist feminists (i.e., those who view sex differences as basically inconsequential, and those who claim that there is a unique female essence associated with birthing/mothering) and concludes that either viewpoint can be used *against* women in patriarchal society. Women need to articulate their own experiences of childbirth but also to subject these personal feelings to critical examination for they are produced in a particular social context that includes some very powerful prescriptions for what mothers should feel.

One very disturbing element of the present social context is the development of reproductive technologies that alienate mother from child, so that the fetus is perceived as the patient—sometimes coequal with the women in whose womb it resides, but increasingly as an entity whose rights can conflict with

those of the mother (e.g., in the case of court-ordered caesarean sections or fetal surgery). Other dilemmas confront women faced with choices about abortion of “defective” fetuses. In a society that defines female, black, and handicapped children as lacking in value, how can women make a “free” choice? Ultimately, the questions raised by Rothman’s analysis are designed to provoke “the articulation of a feminist ideology that can embrace the feelings of women as mothers, the technology of reproduction, and the social context in which both develop.”

As the first two chapters in Part II indicate, not only is female sexuality socially constructed, it is also socially controlled. Political scientist Carole J. Sheffield examines the use of violence or threats of violence—“sexual terrorism”—as a mechanism for keeping women in their place. Sheffield delineates the ideological supports for female subordination, their expression in pornography and such acts of amoral violence as rape, wife assault, the sexual abuse of children, sexual harassment, and sexual slavery. Scholars do not yet know how these various manifestations of anti-female violence are linked to one another or whether their apparent recent increase is a direct response to the new feminist activism. Still there can be no doubt that a growing awareness of their vulnerability has affected millions of American women. The perceptions of victims and their attempts to overcome intimidation are briefly described; but as Sheffield notes at the beginning and end of her chapter, however far we may have moved toward equality, these steps are relatively meaningless if girls and women cannot walk the streets in safety or live in their homes without fear.

Sheffield remarks on the role of the mass media in perpetuating the image of women as victim and in reinforcing stereotypes of masculine power and “honor” that justify sexual terrorism. In the following chapter, sociologist Muriel Cantor details how gender is built into every aspect of mass communications but especially focuses on portrayals of men and women in media primarily directed to female consumers: magazines, romance fiction, and television soap operas. Across the media, over time, regardless of social class and despite enormous changes in the society and culture, one theme remains dominant: the supreme importance of romance in the life of a woman. This is particularly true for the portrayal of sexuality.

Cantor also discusses how such items of popular culture are created and who controls the productive process, as well as the effects of audiences on the content of the material they are offered. For all its modern veneer, women’s fiction continues to construct women’s sexual and social needs in ways that reinforce dependence on men and that perpetuate gender inequality. Cantor notes that women accept these constructions because they provide substitute satisfactions for other, less attainable ideals. Women’s actual subordination creates the demand for fantasies to obscure this reality, while producers of media products for this market are shaping their wares to meet this demand.

PART III: GENDER STRATIFICATION

The imposition of an ideology of two genders and the differential evaluation of these differences has one universal outcome: systems of gender stratification in which males have greater claims on and access to the scarce resources—power, prestige, and property—of a society than do females. The first chapter in this section, by sociologist Susan Tiano, provides an overview of the socioeconomic status of women in developing societies. Using the framework of a critique of three explanatory schema—integration, marginalization, and exploitation—Tiano documents the failure of the world capitalist system to bring prosperity to the vast majority of Third World peoples. Rather, existing stratification hierarchies have been reinforced by the move toward cash/market economies, rapid population growth, and the exclusion of most women from the limited formal work sector, except as poorly paid assemblers.

Throughout the Third World, as the local subsistence economy is replaced by cash crops or assembly-line work for multinational corporations and as men migrate to urban shanty towns, it is poor rural women who have borne the brunt of recent changes. But even women of the small middle-class stratum lose power relative to their husbands. Tiano concludes that both “marginality and exploitation are the twin faces of women’s subordinate status” in the developing nations of Asia, Africa, and Central and South America. Women rendered economically vulnerable in a cash economy can be readily exploited by multinational firms seeking a docile labor force.

Faced with the need to supplement household income through paid employment but still burdened with full responsibility for child care, Third World women drift between the formal and informal work sectors, further eroding their economic position. Nonetheless, Tiano notes the liberating potential of development particularly in the areas of health care and communications. But the obstacles are enormous: imperialism, which oppresses all Third World people; capitalism, which oppresses all wage workers; and patriarchy, which oppresses all women. It is not enough, then, to resist only one of these interlocking systems of power.

Shifting their gaze to the more developed nations, economists Penelope Ciancanelli and Bettina Berch examine systems of gender inequality in industrial society as these have been rationalized by mainstream economic models. Standard economic theory focuses on the individual who is assumed to make rational choices on the basis of a personal calculus of costs and benefits. Thus women’s location in low-paying jobs and their unequal pay scales are explained in terms of choices that workers make in the light of competing demands and perceived opportunity costs. But the tractability of these positivist models is bought at the cost of a narrow perspective that systematically excludes the consideration of power and inequality, so that

stratification is rendered invisible.

Ciancanelli and Berch show how the application of these models to the division of labor at both the societal and household levels has serious inconsistencies. For example, income and work that are essential to making the micro-level models work have to be hidden in order to make the macro-level models usable. Since the work and income that are thus obscured are women’s, it appears that women continue to create anomalies in the paradigm constructed around male labor.

These models are also scientifically dubious as they cannot be disproved: Any choice is *post facto* assumed to reflect the values that a given woman places on leisure, household labor, or paid employment. Like the biological and psychological theories examined by Sayers and by Deaux and Kite, the very premise of orthodox economics rests on the need to discover innate differences in order to rationalize inequality. In discussions of discrimination and comparable worth, mainstream economists revert to political assertions about the invisible hand of the market that they would scarcely take seriously in any context other than sex differences in jobs and pay.

The authors also discuss the work of economists outside the mainstream—primarily feminists and marxists—who have sought to introduce structural elements (including capitalism and patriarchy) into the analysis of labor force segregation and inequitable pay scales. In this perspective, the division of labor in the economy and household are “not simply efficient allocations of tastes, but simultaneously a gendered and hierarchical distribution of status and income.”

Ciancanelli and Berch then examine several scenarios for the future, and find little about which to be sanguine. For example, it is doubtful that free market forces will ultimately reduce male-female labor disparities, or that the electronic cottage will enhance women’s economic power, or that the high-tech revolution will provide women with high status jobs. There are, however, promising “feminist interventionist” strategies to be pursued, such as the current fight for pay equity. Systems of “difference,” whether based on race, gender, or ethnicity, claim the authors, will not automatically fade away. Stratification is not the outcome of neutral allocation processes but the very method of allocation itself.

Despite the many differences between developing and industrial nations, these two chapters reach very similar conclusions, largely because in all societies most women carry a double burden: productive labor within or outside the household, on the one hand, and exclusive responsibility for homemaking and child care on the other. Yet a cloud of gender assumptions regarding work continues to obscure this reality. Sociologist Christine E. Bose represents a needed corrective to most sociohistorical accounts of the ideal and reality of “dual spheres”—that is, the presumed split between a male world of work outside the home and a woman’s world confined to household

and family, as an inevitable outcome of the industrial revolution in Western societies.

Such a formulation neatly excludes the experience of women of color, immigrant "girls," and working-class women in general, most of whom have always maintained some form of paid work. Bose explores the ideological bases of this belief, its functions in maintaining racial, class, and gender stratification systems, and the ways in which U.S. census definitions reinforced the inaccurate classification of women's work in the period of transition from an agricultural to an industrial labor force. Forms of women's paid work that took place in the home were particularly likely to be invisible to census takers. Even when women contributed cash earnings to the household, they still defined themselves primarily as housewives so that their labor was never enumerated. From an analysis of trends in women's employment in this century as well, Bose concludes that the traditional view of dual spheres is being preserved even while currently being adapted to take account of women's segregation within the paid labor force.

The theme of gender inequality in today's work place is further examined by sociologist/economists Paula England and Lori McCreary. The authors carefully review the data on sex segregation in jobs, earnings differentials, and possible differences in nonmonetary rewards, applying various explanatory factors—socialization, human capital characteristics, discrimination in hiring and promotion, and the existence of structured mobility ladders. The authors conclude that no single model is sufficient to explain sex differentials in jobs and pay, but that all these elements interact in a reciprocal feedback loop that has historically tended to reinforce sex discrimination and its long-range effects, but which also has the potential for magnifying a spiral of change once reverse momentum is generated. Such a reversal appears unlikely, however, without more rigorous government enforcement of antidiscrimination statutes in the work place or without greater sharing of household and child-care responsibilities in the home. And neither of these shifts appears imminent so long as Americans continue to believe that paid work is central to manhood and that women would prefer to stay home if it were economically feasible. But this may be an area in which women will create far-reaching change through political struggle as they experience job segregation and pay inequity.

PART IV: GENDERED WORLDS

The themes of conflict and struggle are central to Myra Marx Ferree's analysis of women in paid employment. Ferree explores the meaning of women's expanded labor force participation for the great majority who work in nonelite jobs. Arguing that unconventional behavior by women is not new, and hence hardly nontraditional, Ferree examines the variety of forms of

description of gender based on the lives of white middle-class women understates the traditions of resistance found among most women workers.

The first section of Ferree's chapter provides an overview of the types of jobs occupied by most women workers today and contrasts this reality to the myth of the "liberated" woman professional. Yet even if paid work is not as rewarding or emancipating as is sometimes claimed, it is not without important positive value. The second part of this chapter explores the meanings and rewards of work—paid and unpaid—for women in male-sex-typed and female-sex-typed jobs.

Women's experience in factory, clerical, and service jobs shows class and race to be interrelated structures that produce exclusionary and demeaning behaviors between women as well as solidarity and celebration. The commonalities among women can be used to overcome differences, as indicated in studies of cross-ethnic solidarity in factories, but can also be used to oppress, as illustrated by studies of male harassment of both black and white women in male-typed occupations. Evidence of white women's abuse of nonwhite domestic employees, in contrast, indicates that women's work culture does not automatically arise from the experience of working in a female-typed job. Class and race differences are used in domestic labor to obscure the reality of women's common responsibility for housework. Gender solidarity, when it arises, is actively created by participants as a form of resistance to a shared oppression. Ferree argues that conflicts between workers of the same class but different genders, or same gender but different class, are not inevitable, even if structurally induced. The essay highlights the ways in which workers as active agents make gender, race, and class variably significant within an occupational structure that depends on these divisions and in which employers can exploit their salience.

Resisting exploitation is often linked to fighting for a better chance in life for one's children. For women, resistance can mean struggle to preserve their families as well as an attempt to escape limits that their families impose on them. Family life can be a source of essential gratification, and also an iron cage. The centrality of family and its gendered nature are the subject of chapters by Evelyn Nakano Glenn and Helena Z. Lopata.

Glenn examines three major themes in the feminist reconstruction of family studies. First, she offers an in-depth critique of the androcentrism of leading sociological perspectives on the family. Not only functional analysis but exchange theory and interactionist models fail to appreciate the influence of emotions, power inequality, and conflict on family outcomes. In contrast to the relatively "benign" view of contemporary paradigms, says Glenn, we must continue "to focus consciously on how gender and structures of gender subordination systematically affect interaction and shape definitions of reality."

Second, we must also recognize that the family is not necessarily an entity

constituent parts or subsystems, always remaining aware of actual and potential conflicts between and among its members. Glenn also notes the many links between family and outside institutions, and the overlap of public and private production.

The third focus of a feminist revisioning of the family involves bringing race and class into the center of the analysis. The family that is perceived as oppressive by white middle-class women is often a crucial support system for nonwhite and ethnic working-class women. Indeed, in Barrie Thorne's (1982) words, the family is "a tangle of love and domination" so that women located differently in the stratification system may see only one side of the contradictory position of women in the family. They may experience the family primarily as a source of collective resistance to the atomizing demands of employers or state bureaucrats, or they may perceive the family primarily as a coercive institution that threatens their own individuality and represses their real needs.

The family is such a protean topic that there are a number of ways in which women's familial relationships can be approached. Helena Z. Lopata writes from the life-course perspective currently emerging in social gerontology, as she follows the transformations in role sets—in rights and duties between a person and her social circles—that accompany the journey from girlhood to widowhood in old age. Lopata's multitextured model examines the ways in which gender expectations and sexual stratification constrain choices and shape identities at all ages, despite considerable variation within the female population. She highlights the variability between expectations at different moments in the life course, as American women adopt different family roles from daughter to grandmother and including stepmother and mother-in-law. Even when the ideology of "femininity" or "sex role" would define these divergent roles as identical or at least continuous, the gender perspective that Lopata adopts makes their inconsistency visible and significant.

The relationship of women to religion and religious structures in the United States has been somewhat ambiguous, to say the least. Although women account for the majority of worshipers, and although American churches have, over time, become feminized in the sense that they are perceived as instruments of succor, these established religious bodies also represent the essence of male dominance in their leadership, doctrine, and language. Theologian Sheila Briggs details the feminist critique of Western religions as bulwarks of patriarchy. Briggs describes the struggle of religious feminists to claim full participation in governance and ritual, while also trying to express a distinctive female voice. These two thrusts—exemplified in the debates over ordination and over nonsexist discourse—are fully examined for both mainstream and Afro-American churches.

Briggs's description of the experiences of women in the Afro-American religious tradition provides many important and often overlooked insights.

For example, the way in which women in the congregation direct the style and content of male preaching is explored.

Another societal sphere in which women predominate as receivers of services is the health care system, which shares many of the structural properties of the religious system: controlled almost exclusively by men, built on gendered assumptions about sex differences, and practiced primarily on women. As in the case of religion, the gender hierarchy of the medical establishment became an early target of feminist revisioning. That the doctor-patient relationship reflected the power inequities of the larger system was galling enough, but critics also objected to the content and quality of the health care being provided to women by physicians (of either sex) trained in the American medical tradition.

Mary K. Zimmerman's chapter analyzes both the causes of dissatisfaction among female patients and the attempts to create an alternative system of health care. She describes how the women's health movement emerged in the 1960s to deal with problems of health and illness that were either ignored or misinterpreted by the existing system and then began to move beyond criticism to the actual delivery of health care in nonhierarchical settings. Sympathetically but critically, Zimmerman delineates the successes and failures of various facets of the movement. Alternative health care systems remain subordinate to the legal and political power of the medical establishment while efforts to integrate medicine and to transform it from within often fail to resist cooptation. The paradox is illustrated by the divergent paths chosen by Florence Nightingale and Elizabeth Blackwell; while neither route separately has proved successful, the potential of a combined assault on the medical establishment has yet to be fully tested.

PART V: GENDER AND THE STATE

The final three chapters bring us back to a consideration of the state as product and producer of gender inequality. Ava Baron's discussion of feminist legal strategies embodies many of the major threads woven through this volume. First, there is the law as reification of gender ideology, its manifest support for patriarchal relationships, and its treatment of women as "Other." Second, American legal efforts to extend the rights of women reflect the same tension between formal equality (based on the assumption of sameness) and recognition of women's unique biological role as mother (the assumption of difference) that is evident in most of the other chapters.

Laws designed to protect privacy—reflecting a "hands off" policy—fail to protect women from abuse and exploitation, but when the patriarchal state does intervene, the effects are also frequently harmful to women. Baron traces the contradictory outcomes of legal strategies in such crucial areas as family

relationships, violence against women, reproductive control, and work and earnings, noting in each instance the limitations of pursuing legal equality as an end in itself.

Despite such shortcomings, Baron also sees the legal system as a viable area for resistance, conflict, and basic change. The essay concludes with an outline of a feminist jurisprudence capable of attacking the structural sources of inequality. Two immediate goals are (1) to recognize the interlocking nature of public and private spheres for women, and (2) to clarify the intersections of class, race, and gender, as these are currently obscured in the law. So enormous a task cannot be accomplished by any single strategy, and consensus is not necessarily desirable. As with the medical system, the legal system may be most susceptible to change when it is challenged from many angles simultaneously.

The dual themes of public versus private spheres and the sameness versus difference debate appear once more in the chapter by political scientists Irene Diamond and Martha Ackelsberg. They find that feminist rethinking in political science, as in so many other disciplines, has taken three forms: (1) critiques of the conventional (male) views of women in both classic texts and empirical studies; (2) "reading" women into traditional paradigms; and (3) transforming the paradigms. Relegating women to the private (read "nonpolitical") sphere is a defining characteristic of political philosophy from Plato to Podhoretz. Consequently, only public displays of power have been studied as "politics," ignoring completely the private realm as an arena of political behavior or the possibility that sex differences in political behavior do not reflect innate biological traits. The gender perspective, in contrast, emphasizes the *social construction* of such differences and identifies the beneficiaries of traditional interpretations.

Feminist scholars in political science seek to revise and correct the basic models of their field through studies of women as political actors and as objects of public policy, most particularly as clients of the welfare state. The role of the state is itself subject to debate between those who see intervention as buffering the impact of capitalism and patriarchy and those who are more skeptical about the efficacy of state policy.

The effort to restructure political theory has centered around the issue of dealing with women's "difference" without reviving the public/private dichotomy and without erasing recognition of the differences among women. Diamond and Ackelsberg review the most recent writings in this ongoing debate, concluding that both mainstream individualism in political theory and the emphasis on class divisions of Marxism fail to appreciate the fact that women's political involvement has long been contingent on their experiences as members of primary groups—families, friendship networks, and neighborhoods. Politics, therefore, is best reconceptualized not as the study of power but of communities in action.

The book closes with a chapter that links the personal to the global and forces us to consider the worldwide consequences of gendered and stratified modes of knowledge and control. Political scientist Cynthia Enloe presents a feminist analysis of militarization as a social process in part fueled by the concept of masculinity as something distinct from femininity, thus explaining its existence in societies at different stages of economic and political development and across the range of human history. By thus placing gender at the heart of the issue, Enloe also points to the possibility of a feminist analysis that could reverse this deadly process by showing how militarization "is a surface symptom of more basic assumptions in the culture about marriage, property, reproduction, and heterosexuality—all of which are essential to the maintenance of male privilege." At the same time, Enloe argues that militarization is not merely masculinity writ large, as evidenced by the considerable efforts required to inculcate military attitudes and behaviors in men and by the active roles women play in military activities in most societies, including our own. While dichotomous gender ideology obscures the participation of women in militarization, the conceptual categories of war and peace also mask the reality of militarization as an ongoing and spiraling process.

Further, a focus on the connections between masculinity and militarization brings us closer to the thinking and theorizing of Third World women, who cannot separate fears for their survival into neat categories of national security or domestic violence. Finally, militarization also injures men, in open and hidden ways, so that they too may come to realize that they have as much to lose as to gain from patriarchal structures and assumptions of masculinity and femininity.

In the course of bringing gender analysis to bear on the salient issues of contemporary social science, the authors have inevitably raised new questions, further stimulating the dialectic that makes this such an exciting and fruitful field of study today. We hope that a new generation of scholars will see this volume as another milestone in the emerging discourse on gender and society. The primary task ahead, as implied by so many of our authors and forcefully stated by Diamond and Ackelsberg, is not to replace a disembodied "masculine" rationalism with some sort of "feminine" irrationality, but rather to transform our ways of seeing and knowing in order to give an expanded and integrated account of reason *and* emotion, thought *and* experience, individuality *and* connectedness in our daily lives and beyond.

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